

Lifestyle Guidelines Based on the Traffic Light Approach: A Simple Guide to Better Health

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July 25, 2026

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Most chronic diseases develop gradually through thousands of everyday choices—what we eat, how much we move, how well we sleep, how we manage stress, and whether we avoid harmful habits. While these choices are simple in principle, consistently making healthier decisions is often difficult. The Lifestyle Guideline based on the Traffic Light Approach (LG-TLA) was developed to make healthy decisions easier.

One in three Americans suffers from a chronic disease, which consumes 90% of US health care budget. Non-Communicable Diseases are a rising tide globally (World Health Organization 2023). There is sufficient evidence now that our behavior change not only helps in the prevention of disease, but also improves outcomes so much so that it can lead to reversal of chronic conditions (technically called remission) (Katz et al. 2014) (Lloyd-Jones et al. 2022). Despite the evidence, and widespread awareness of this fact accomplishing behaviour change is hard, both for individuals and clinicians. One of the reasons for this dichotomy is lack of a comprehensive guide, as well as measure of good behaviour that is flexible and respects individual agency.

A new Health Building Guideline (abbreviated here as Lifestyle Guideline based on Traffic Light Approach, or LG-TLA) fills this gap (Sarwal et al. 2026). Based firmly on scientific evidence, the Traffic Light Approach groups foods and lifestyle habits into three simple categories:

Green practice regularly Red avoid or minimize Yellow improve gradually

Health is not shaped by a single meal, a short-term diet, or a temporary lifestyle change—it is built through the choices we make every day. The 21-point LG-TLA based on the Traffic Light Approach emphasizes that sustainable health comes from creating consistent habits that support the whole person. While nutrition plays a central role, long-term well-being also depends on regular physical activity, quality sleep, stress management, hydration, body weight, and avoidance of harmful behaviors and other daily practices that strengthen the body and mind.

LG-TLA provides individuals with a practical way to evaluate their lifestyle score at any time. This structured approach helps individuals identify opportunities for improvement, set realistic goals, and transform health recommendations into sustainable daily actions. By adopting these Lifestyle Habits, individuals can build a practical foundation for lifelong health, improve overall quality of life, and reduce the risk of chronic diseases. This article presents the guideline in a practical and accessible format for the general public.

!["Lifestyle Guideline"](<./English.jpeg>){width="800" height="600"}

Green Light Foods: nutrient-supportive foods, balanced diets The Healthy Building Lifestyle Guidelines encourage eating a balanced diet that includes foods from all seven major food groups, with an emphasis on fresh, seasonal, and locally produced foods whenever possible. This approach supports nutrient adequacy, dietary diversity, and long-term health while encouraging sustainable eating habits (World Health Organization 2020). The recommended Green Light food groups include:

- **Vegetables:** Choose a variety of seasonal vegetables, especially green leafy vegetables, along with fresh salads such as beetroot, cucumber, and radish. Traditional chutneys made with coriander, mint, chilies, garlic, ginger, and Indian gooseberry (amla) can also provide flavor and beneficial plant compounds. Vegetables supply vitamins, minerals, fiber, and thousands of beneficial plant compounds that support heart, gut, and immune health.
- **Fruits:** Enjoy a variety of seasonal fruits to increase intake of vitamins, minerals, fiber, and antioxidants.
- **Whole Grains and Cereals:** Prioritize whole grains such as whole wheat, parboiled rice, and traditional millets like bajra (pearl millet), jowar (sorghum), and ragi (finger millet). Fermented grain preparations and cereal-pulse combinations can further enhance nutritional value and digestibility.
- **Pulses and Legumes:** Include whole pulses, beans, sprouted lentils, and chickpeas (gram), which are excellent sources of plant-based protein, fiber, and essential nutrients.
- **Dairy:** Choose lower-fat dairy options such as toned milk, plain yogurt (curd), and buttermilk to provide calcium, protein, and beneficial probiotics.
- **Healthy Fats:** Prepare foods using small amounts of oil and favor healthier cooking methods such as steaming or boiling. The guidelines also recommend adding a small amount of ghee to prepared foods, recognizing its traditional role in balanced diets when consumed in moderation (Estruch et al. 2018).
- **Natural Sweeteners:** When sweetness is desired, choose natural options such as jaggery, honey, dates, or raisins in moderation, while keeping overall added sugar intake low.

Red Light Foods: Foods to Avoid for Better Health (ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition Expert Committee 2024) One of the core principles of LG-TLA is reducing foods that contribute to chronic inflammation, excess calorie intake, and poor metabolic health. These "Red Light" foods are best avoided because they are often high in salt, refined sugar, refined grains, and unhealthy fats ingredients linked to obesity, diabetes, cardiovascular disease, and other chronic health conditions when consumed regularly. Examples of Red Light foods include:

- Deep-fried foods: French fries, pakoras, samosas, kachoris, and other fried snacks control remains important because it is high in fat and calories (Qin et al. 2021).
- Processed and packaged foods: Potato chips, patties, packaged breads, biscuits, and many commercially prepared sauces (Dai et al. 2024).
- Sugary treats and confectionery: Candy, chocolates, toffees, cakes, pastries, ice cream, and other desserts high in added sugar (Lara-Castor et al. 2025).
- Sugar-sweetened beverages: Soft drinks, sodas, and other carbonated beverages (Reynolds et al. 2019).
- Milk-based caffeinated beverages: Avoid Tea and coffee prepared with milk and added sugar.
- Red meat: Frequent consumption of processed meats and large amounts of red meat should be limited.
- Alcoholic beverages: Alcohol provides little nutritional value and is associated with numerous adverse health outcomes.
- Red lifestyle habit points to addictive substances that needs to be shunned.

Yellow Light Choices: Small Changes That Lead to Lasting Habits: Good nutrition is only one part of a healthy lifestyle. The Healthy Building Lifestyle Guidelines also emphasize daily habits that support physical, mental, and metabolic well-being. Together, these behaviors create a strong foundation for preventing chronic disease and improving overall quality of life. The Yellow Light represents the transition zone choices that should be gradually improved as part of a healthier lifestyle. Rather than striving for perfection, the goal is to make steady, sustainable progress toward healthier habits. Examples of Yellow Light choices include:

- Move: Physical activity: If 30 minutes of daily exercise (World Health Organization 2024) feels overwhelming, begin with shorter sessions and gradually increase duration and intensity over time. Aim for at least 30 minutes of walking, exercise, yoga (Cramer, Lauche, and others 2017), or pranayama (breathing exercises) to improve cardiovascular health, strength, flexibility, and stress management (Bull et al. 2020).

- Sleep: Prioritize quality sleep (Wang and Boros 2022).
- Stress: Managing stress is essential for both physical and mental health.
- Getting daily sun exposure. Safe exposure to sunlight helps support the body’s natural production of vitamin D, which plays an important role in bone health, immune function, and overall well-being.
- Maintain a healthy body weight. Strive for a Body Mass Index (BMI) below 25 and reduce excess abdominal fat, which is associated with an increased risk of diabetes, heart disease, and other chronic conditions.
- Staying well hydrated. Drink enough water throughout the day to support digestion, circulation, temperature regulation, and overall body function.
- Meal time and portions: Avoid overeating by practicing mindful eating and recognizing hunger and fullness cues. Establish consistent mealtimes. Eating meals at regular times and avoiding overeating can support healthy digestion, appetite regulation, and metabolic health.
- Screen time: Reducing excessive screen use does not have to happen overnight. Setting realistic limits and replacing screen time with physical activity or relaxation can support healthier daily routines.

This simple framework helps people assess their current habits, set achievable goals, and track progress over time. It has many strengths. Firstly, it combines diet and lifestyle choices and places them into intuitive, three color coded groups following the Traffic Light Approach. Secondly, it is amenable to measurement - both at baseline and over time - enabling a quantitative scoring and review of progress. Thirdly, by placing foods into broad groups within which individuals can choose based on their circumstances and preferences, it respects individual choice; rather, the LG-TLA gives individual the control over their health, while playing the role of a guide and advisor.

In our clinical experience, patients adopting this guideline and shifting to higher score report better bowel movement, greater energy during the day, better sleep besides relief from distressing symptoms of metabolic, chronic diseases like hypertension, diabetes, arthritis, menstrual disorders and functional gastro-intestinal disorders. While these observations are encouraging, formal evaluation is ongoing.

From Knowledge to Action Building a Healthier Lifestyle One Choice at a Time Healthy eating is not about perfection it is about making better choices consistently. The Healthy Building Lifestyle Guidelines provide practical recommendations for nourishing the body through whole foods, regular physical activity, adequate hydration, restorative sleep, stress management, and other daily habits that support long-term health. Building on these principles, the Traffic Light Approach offers a complementary, behavior-centered framework that transforms health recommendations into simple, actionable decisions. Rather than focusing only on individual nutrients, the LG-TLA organizes both food choices and lifestyle behaviors into three easy-to-understand categories:

What distinguishes these guidelines is its emphasis on behavior change rather than information alone. By bridging the gap between knowledge and action, the Traffic Light Approach provides a practical road map for reducing chronic disease risk, improving quality of life, and creating lifelong habitsone healthy choice at a time. LG-TLA strengthens the journey towards better health through lifestyle by strengthening all three pillars of behaviour change - capability (C), opportunity (O), and motivation (M) contained in the COM-B model. The Traffic Light Approach is not about perfectionit is about helping you make one better choice today than yesterday.

"Learn More": Start small, stay consistent, and track your progress. Make one one better choice today than yesterday. Share your experience in the comments to inspire others. Readers may assess their lifestyle score using the online LG-TLA assessment tool developed on these guidelines (Quality and Quality 2026).

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